Harbor Lights at Dawn

The first boat leaves the harbor before the sun is up. Its lamps move across the water in a slow line, and the station keeper writes down the time each one passes the breakwater. On calm mornings the count is easy. On rough ones the lamps vanish behind the swell and come back. The keeper then tells the boats apart by the color of each mast light.

The log for this page holds forty mornings. Most boats left within ten minutes of each other. Two did not leave at all, because the harbor master closed the channel for a sunken buoy.

The Granite Lighthouse

The tower stands on a ledge of pink granite at the end of the point. Its walls are four feet thick at the base and taper to two at the lamp room. The stone came from a quarry three miles inland. Carts carried it down in the dry summer months.

Each spring the keeper checks the mortar between the blocks. Salt eats into it a little each year, and the worst joints are packed with fresh lime. In good weather the work takes a week.

Salt Marsh Herons

Behind the dunes lies a marsh that floods twice a day. Great blue herons stand in the shallow channels and wait for small fish to come within reach. The keeper counts them from the gallery rail with a brass telescope.

In a good year the marsh holds thirty birds. In a dry year the tide creeks silt up and the count drops below ten. The birds then move north to the river mouth.

Winter Storm Records

From November to March the station keeps a storm book. Each entry gives the wind direction, the highest gust the gauge showed, and the height of the waves at the end of the jetty. The worst storm in the book pushed water over the road and into the oil house.

The keeper also notes which boats stayed out and which came back early. The harbor master reads the book each spring to plan the mooring lines.

Tidal Pools and Crabs

At low tide the rocks below the tower hold dozens of small pools. Green crabs hide under the weed, and hermit crabs drag their borrowed shells across the sand at the bottom. Children from the village come to look on summer afternoons.

The keeper marks the largest pools on a chart and checks them once a month. A pool that dries out in a heat wave is empty for the rest of the season.

Mapping the Sandbars

The bars at the mouth of the bay move with every storm. Twice a year the keeper rows out with a lead line and a compass and sounds the channel at each marker. The depths go onto a grid drawn on heavy paper.

If a bar comes within six feet of the surface at low water, the station sends word to the harbor master. He moves the channel buoys before the fishing season opens.

Kelp Forest Survey

South of the point the bottom drops to forty feet, and a bed of kelp grows there in long brown ropes. Divers from the college come each August to count the plants along a line of weighted ropes.

The station lends them its dory and stores their tanks in the boat shed. In return they leave a copy of their counts, which the keeper pins to the wall beside the tide tables.

Driftwood Cabin Notes

A small cabin built from driftwood stands at the far end of the beach. Nobody knows who built it. The keeper walks out to it after each storm to see whether the roof is still on.

Over the years the cabin lost its door, two windows, and most of its porch. Each loss goes into a notebook kept on a shelf inside, with the date and the wind that did it.

The Old Ferry Route

Before the bridge was built, a ferry crossed the bay four times a day. Its landing still stands at the foot of the village, and the posts of the waiting room lean out over the water.

The station log from those years records each crossing. On foggy days the ferry blew its horn every minute. The keeper answered with the bell, and the captain judged his distance from the rocks by its sound.

Seawall Repairs

A stone wall protects the road between the village and the point. Waves break against it all winter, and each spring a few stones are loose or fallen out. The town sends a crew with a crane and a load of new blocks.

The keeper walks the wall with the crew chief and points out the weak places. The crews rebuilt the worst section, near the old boat ramp, three times.

Gull Colony Counts

Herring gulls nest on the bare island a mile offshore. In June the keeper rows out on a calm day and walks the island with a tally counter. The eggs lie hidden in the grass, so each step is slow.

The colony grew each year after the fish plant opened in the village. The last count found more than four hundred nests, twice the number of the count ten years before.

Oyster Beds in Spring

The shallow cove west of the tower holds a bed of wild oysters. When the water warms in April, the oysters begin to feed, and the cove turns cloudy with the silt they stir up.

The town opens the bed to harvest for two weeks at the end of spring. The keeper measures the water temperature each morning and posts it on the board by the landing.

Fog Signal Station

A horn house stands below the tower on a concrete pad. When the fog comes in, the keeper starts the engine that drives the air pump, and the horn sounds two blasts every thirty seconds.

Some summers the horn runs for days at a time. The engine needs oil every four hours, and the keeper keeps a cot in the horn house so as not to miss a change.

Lantern Room Logbook

At the top of the tower, beside the lamp, a logbook records every night the light was lit. Each line gives the time of lighting, the time of putting out, and the oil burned.

The oldest pages are in brown ink. The newest are in pencil. Together they cover more than ninety years of nights, with only a few gaps where a page was torn out or lost.